Living animals must not be fed with (other) living animals.

Fish are inviolable, and must not be sold, on the three Chaturmasis (and) on the Tishya full-moon during three days, (viz.) the fourteenth, the fifteenth, (and) the first (*tithi*), and invariably on every fast-day.

And during these same days also no other classes of animals which are in the elephant-park (and) in the preserves of the fishermen, must be killed.

On the eighth (*tithi*) of (every) fortnight, on the fourteenth, on the fifteenth, on Tishya, on Punarvasu, on the three Chaturmasis, (and) on festivals, bulls must not be castrated, (and) he-goats, rams, boars, and whatever other (animals) are castrated (otherwise) must not be castrated (then).

On Tishya, on Punarvasu, on the Chaturmasis, (and) during the fortnight of (every) Chaturmasi, horses (and) bullocks must not be branded.[32]

The first question about this massive range of animals needing protection is whether such care is enjoined in sacred texts. For the most part, animals in the texts of ancient India are classified according to various principles such as anatomical characteristics and modes of procreation, domestication and wildness, suitability for sacrifice or not, edible or inedible.[33] In some texts (such as the *Satapatha Brahmana*, *Aitareya Brahmana*, and the *Manu Smriti*) beasts not worthy of sacrifice are considered unfit for human consumption.[34] Ashoka could in theory have had such injunctions in mind when compiling his don't-hit list.

The scholar K.R. Norman believes parallels are discernible between the Ashokan list and certain Jaina texts. Ashoka's list is not random but carefully organized to include two talking birds, a series of aquatic birds (the bat mentioned here being a water-haunting one), aquatic animals, reptiles (legged and legless), and three birds of the pigeon/dove family.[35] Ashoka, in Norman's opinion, is following a division of animal life enumerated in Jaina texts: sky-goers, water-goers, and land-goers, which shows the influence upon him in this respect of Jainism. Even the creature named 'palaste' in the list, which Hultzsch translates as 'rhinoceros', is read